

film review Memory and Lapse

U ME AUR HUM

Director: Ajay Devgan

Starring: Ajay Devgan,
Kajol

There's a bouncy baby drowning in the bath tub while its mother is riveted by a lizard trying to snap up a moth, there's a grown man trying not to weep as the rain pours down in artistic swathes around him, and a beautiful young woman suffering from the slow terror of Alzheimer's. It's all shot in extreme close-up, and is digitally coloured to tweak at the heartstrings. On the surface, everything is perfect in actor Ajay Devgan's directorial debut—the water is Mediterranean blue and the monsoon sky is Turner-like stormy, as seen through Aseem Bajaj's camera. Starting out as a meditation on life after



LACK ZING: Devgan and Kajol in *U Me Aur Hum*

marriage—a subject examined in great depth by Bollywood recently, from *Chalte Chalte* to *Kabhi Alvida Naa Kehna*—the film becomes a meditation on mental disability, while taking a detour on the nature of friendship (though a more irritating bunch of buddies is yet to be featured in a Bollywood movie). But there is only so much discussion that the hippocampus—if nothing else, the movie increases your medical vocabulary—

can take. Cringing where one is supposed to cry is not the emotion that Devgan would like us to have, but unfortunately even watching the gorgeous Kajol, with a touch of too much bronzer, pull out all the stops in the role of a woman who is forgetting her life, is not enough. Perhaps the director should have stuck to remaking Hollywood's weepathon *The Notebook* instead of just borrowing its premise.

by Kaveree Bamzai

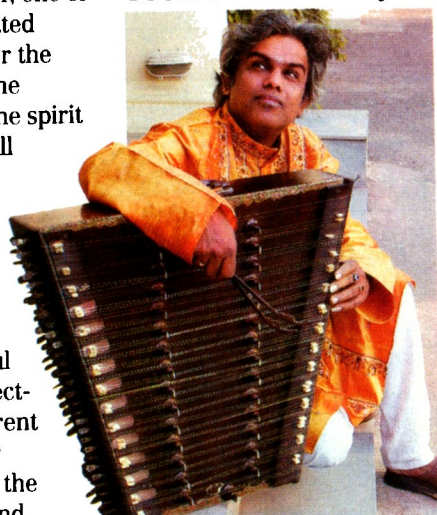
recommendations In Remembrance

BANGALORE Bangaloreans can look forward to a theatre festival celebrating 100 years of Vaikom Muhammed Basheer, one of India's most celebrated writers. Titled *Under the Mangosteen Tree*, the festival celebrates the spirit of the writer and will feature the play, *Sangati Arinhyu*. Directed by Rajiv Krishnan the play has been adapted from Basheer's short stories by Paul Mathew. The connecting link in the different stories is the writer himself "who plays the narrator, witness and

participant". The festival will also feature a week long photo exhibition of rare archival pictures of Basheer and a food festival of Moppla Cuisine. At Ranga Shankara from April 22 to 27.

by Nirmala Ravindran

SOULFUL: Bhattacharya



MUMBAI Classical music thrives in smaller gatherings. And there are two such gatherings that are going to bestow some happiness on the listeners. At the Raagranjan concert, Khayal Trust brings together santoor maestro Pandit Tarun Bhattacharya, Aneesh Pradhan (tabla) and vocalist Manjusha Patil Kulkarni on April 24 at the Karnataka Sangha Auditorium. Also, don't miss a presentation by the Divya Sangeet Kala Foundation that features Bhavdeep Jaipurwale (vocal), Pandit Ulhas Bapat (santoor) and Ashwini Bhide Deshpande (vocal) on April 28. At the Ravindra Natya Mandir, Prabhadevi.

theatre

Historical Journey



A still from the play

DELHI Next week, theatre lovers can rejoice with the screening of the play *1857: Ek Safarnama* (A Journey). Directed by one of the leading personalities of contemporary theatre Nadira Babbar, the play brings out some of the interesting characters of the time—Ramsaran, a labourer who is fed up of the atrocities inflicted on him and Shamsuddin, a renegade subedar. Turned friends, they work as needle and thread to encompass others, whether it be Nana Saheb Peshwa or Tatyia Tope. Babbar has perfectly coined metaphorical dialogues. Costumes have been designed by Oscar-awardee Bhanu Athaiya and lights, handled by Ashok Sagar Bhagat, add striking effects to the play. The fight scenes have been choreographed by Hassan Raghu, a legendary name in the field of stunts. It's not the first time that the play is being staged at Purana Qila. Ibrahim Alkazi, the founder of modern Indian theatre, used its ramparts for the first time in 1960s. M.K. Raina repeated this in 1977 with Dharmveer Bharti's *Andha Yug*. At Purana Qila from April 18 to 25.

by Sheekesh Mishra